

Left (top to bottom) The beautiful courtyard setting of the Al-Khawali restaurant in Damascus, Syria; alfresco dining in Istanbul, overlooking the Bosphorus; meze in Egypt

Below (top to bottom) Greek meze, with olives, fava beans (foreground), octopus, and (center left) char-grilled halloumi cheese; arranging cold meze dishes at a Lebanese restaurant



La Tabkha moderate

Rue Gouraud, Gemmayzeh, Beirut; +961 1 579 000

Modern, minimalist, and contemporary, La Tabkha serves a terrific array of modern Lebanese dishes with a touch of French influence, including an excellent lunch-time meze buffet that changes daily.

Shahrazad moderate

6th Floor, Centre Commercial de Yaghi & Simbole, off Rue Abdel Halim Hajjar, Baalbek; +961 8 371 851

The location may lack style or atmosphere, but it's the spectacular views over Baalbek's Roman ruins that draw a loyal following, along with the simple but hearty and well-prepared home cooking, including a good selection of delicious, freshly prepared meze.

EGYPT

At one time part and parcel of the Ottoman empire and today part of the Middle East, Egypt has long been influenced by both regions' cooking. It has also developed its own distinct versions of meze, using local ingredients and cooking traditions.

Samakmak moderate

42 Qar Ras At Tin, Alexandria; +20 3 481 1560

Established by a former belly dancer, the Samakmak is a cozy, intimate, and atmospheric restaurant. It is best known for its excellent, imaginatively prepared fish and seafood dishes, which include an unusual and very good meze selection.

Abou El Sid expensive

157 Sharia 26 July, Zamalek, Cairo; +20 2 2735 9640

Styled like an Orientalist boudoir-restaurant-bar, the Abou El Sid is one of Cairo's eating hot spots. Diners recline on cushions pasha-style around low brass tables while tucking into well-prepared traditional Egyptian cooking, including mouthwatering meze. Reservations are essential.

CYPRUS

Though unquestionably influenced by Turkey and Greece as well as the Middle East, Cyprus nonetheless proudly possesses its own culinary traditions. The Cypriots love and value their food and keep up a vigorous tradition of meze.

Fetta's inexpensive

Ioanni Agroti 33, Pafos; +357 2693 7822

One of Cyprus's top traditional restaurants, Fetta's bases its reputation on enduring culinary values: quality ingredients, locally sourced, and simple but sound home cooking passed down the generations. The meze platter of grilled meats is a specialty.

Zanettos Taverna inexpensive

Trikoupi 65, Lefkosia; +357 2276 5501

One of the oldest surviving tavernas in the Old City, Zanettos is a bit of an institution and retains a loyal local following. Though located in a rather lugubrious part of town, it's worth the journey: the meze are superb and the atmosphere convivial and fun.

On the Menu in Turkey

Acı domates ezmesi Spicy tomato dip.

Ançüz Pickled anchovies.

Arnavut ciğeri Diced, fried lamb liver with raw onion, sumac, chili pepper, and chopped parsley.

Barbunya pilaki Salad of red beans.

Beyaz peynir White sheep or goat cheese.

Cacık Yogurt with grated cucumber and mint, served either as a kind of soup or as a dip.

Çerkez tavuğu Literally, "Circassian chicken" — chicken, walnuts, and bread flavored with garlic.

Deniz börülcesi Samphire dressed with olive oil, garlic, and lemon and traditionally served with fish and seafood meze.

Enginar Boiled artichoke.

Ezme salatası Tomato and pepper dip.

Fasulye piyazı Salad of navy beans.

Fava or fava salatası A puréed fava bean dip.

Haydari Yogurt dip made with garlic and mint.

Kabak çiçeği dolması Stuffed zucchini flowers.

Kısır Salad made of spiced bulgur wheat.

Lakerda Tuna fish, sliced and salted.

Mercimek köftesi Spicy balls made of red lentils and bulgur wheat traditionally served at weddings and family feasts.

Midye dolması Stuffed mussels.

Patates köftesi Cheese and potato croquettes.

Patlıcan biber tava Fried eggplant and sweet green peppers with tomato sauce and chili pepper.

Patlıcan ezmesi Roast eggplant with yogurt.

Patlıcan kızartması or salatası Fried eggplant and tomato, served warm or as a salad.

Sarımsaklı havuç Grated carrot in a garlicky yogurt.

Semizotu salatası Salad of purslane in a yogurt and garlic dressing.

Sigara böreği Cigar-shaped pastries deep-fried and stuffed with cheese.

Yaprak dolması Vine leaves stuffed with pine nuts, rice, and herbs.